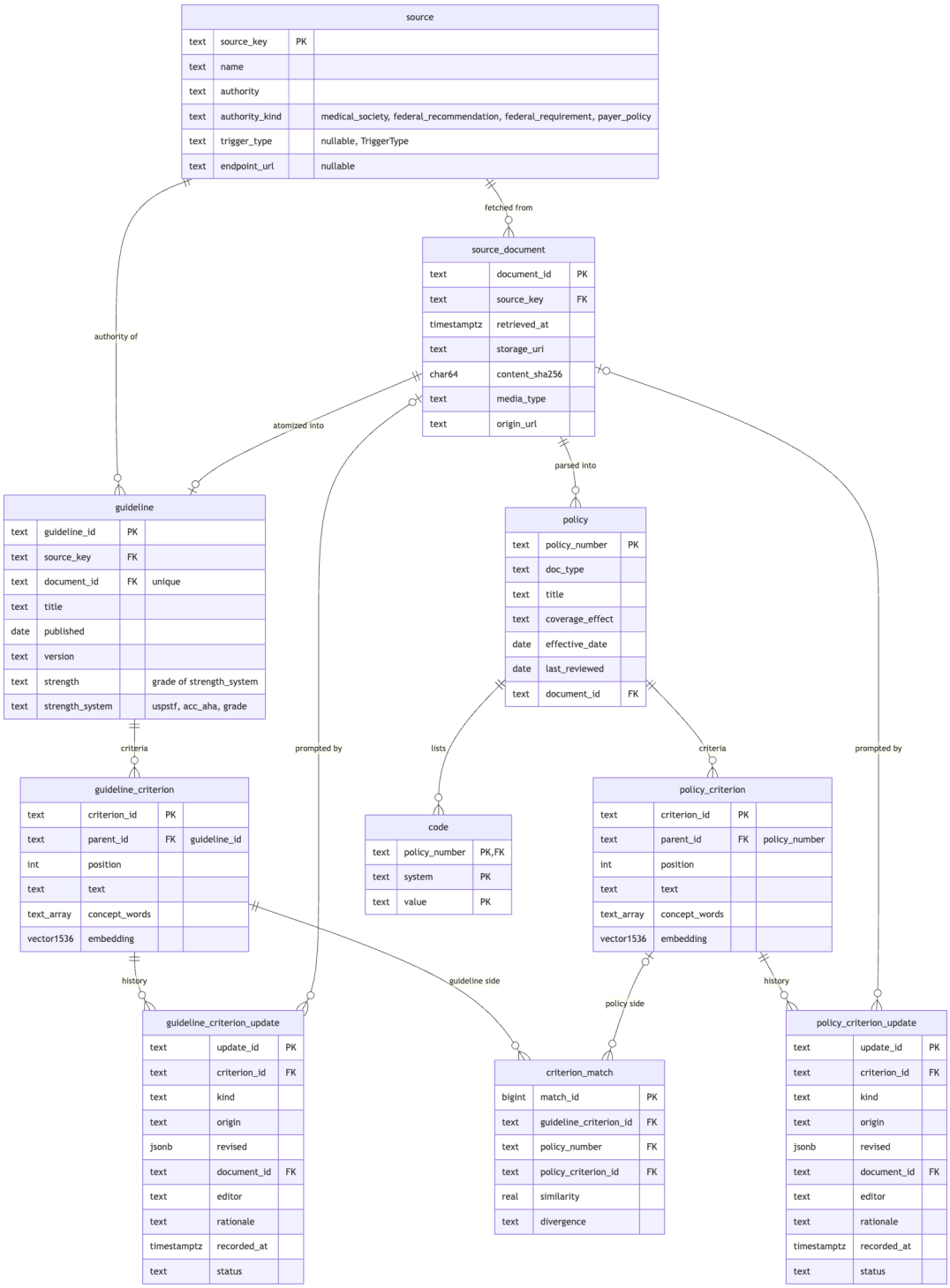
Policy Radar — Backend Spec v0

Status: **implemented v0, not yet run against a database or the OpenAI API** (Postgres 15+ and pgvector ≥ 0.5 required; Supabase has both). Keep this file in step with the code: `db/schema.sql`, `policy_radar/`. `tests/test_schema.py` fails if the SQL tables, the pydantic models and the enums drift apart. The PDF (`docs/BACKEND_SPEC.pdf`) is rendered from this file — see Rendering.

Data model

Ten domain records, one table each, plus a `job` table for pipeline status. Pydantic models are in `policy_radar/models.py`; the DDL is `db/schema.sql`. Column-level detail is under Tables.


source
text source_key PK
text name
text authority
text authority_kind medical_society, federal_recommendation, federal_requirement, payer_policy
text trigger_type nullable, TriggerType
text endpoint_url nullable
fetched from
source_document
text document_id PK
text source_key FK
timestamptz retrieved_at
text storage_uri
char64 content_sha256
text media_type
text origin_url
authority of
atomized into
parsed into
guideline
text guideline_id PK
text source_key FK
text document_id FK unique
text title
date published
text version
text strength grade of strength_system
text strength_system uspstf, acc_aha, grade
policy
text policy_number PK
text doc_type
text title
text coverage_effect
date effective_date
date last_reviewed
text document_id FK
criteria
prompted by
lists
criteria
prompted by
guideline_criterion
text criterion_id PK
text parent_id FK guideline_id
int position
text text
text_array concept_words
vector1536 embedding
code
text policy_number PK,FK
text system PK
text value PK
policy_criterion
text criterion_id PK
text parent_id FK policy_number
int position
text text
text_array concept_words
vector1536 embedding
history
guideline side
policy side
history
guideline_criterion_update
text update_id PK
text criterion_id FK
text kind
text origin
jsonb revised
text document_id FK
text editor
text rationale
timestamptz recorded_at
text status
criterion_match
bigint match_id PK
text guideline_criterion_id FK
text policy_number FK
text policy_criterion_id FK
real similarity
text divergence
policy_criterion_update
text update_id PK
text criterion_id FK
text kind
text origin
jsonb revised
text document_id FK
text editor
text rationale
timestamptz recorded_at
text status

Object storage

Local filesystem for now, rooted at `STORAGE_ROOT` (default `data/objects/`).

```
data/objects/
  {source_key}/
    {sha256}{ext}        e.g. openfda_drug_label/3f9c…e1.json, cpb_upload/a01b…77.pdf
```

`source_document.storage_uri` holds the key (`openfda_drug_label/3f9c…e1.json`), not a path, so the same keys work unchanged in a Supabase Storage bucket. Keys are content-addressed, so storing the same bytes twice writes once. Only `policy_radar/storage.py` knows where objects live.

Scope

This version covers only getting data in:

1. **Ingest guidelines** — fetch documents from the guideline sources (seven APIs and two web pages, each a row in `source`), and store each unchanged original as a `SourceDocument`.
2. **Atomize guidelines** — turn each stored guideline document into a `Guideline` with criteria, using OpenAI structured outputs, and embed each criterion.
3. **Parse CPBs** — accept uploaded Clinical Policy Bulletins, store them as `SourceDocuments`, and parse each into a `Policy` with criteria and codes.

Not in scope: matching a guideline change to policies. The tables `guideline_criterion_update`, `policy_criterion_update` and `criterion_match` exist so the data model matches the design diagram, but no code writes them yet. Expect the data model to change once matching is designed.

Stack: Python 3.12, FastAPI, Postgres + pgvector (Supabase later), asyncpg with plain SQL (no ORM, no migrations tool), OpenAI API, local-filesystem object storage.

Tables

`source`

One row per endpoint or page we fetch from, seeded by `db/schema.sql` (re-applying the schema updates the rows). Every key in `sources.SOURCES` plus `cpb_upload` has a row; `tests/test_schema.py` fails if either side drifts.

Column	Type	Key / constraint	Notes
source_key	text	**PK**	the key `GET /sources` returns
name	text	not null	
authority	text	not null	the body behind it
authority_kind	text	not null, check ∈ `AuthorityKind`	how urgently its changes matter, below
trigger_type	text	check ∈ `TriggerType`	which policies it can send back into review; null for uploads
endpoint_url	text		null for uploads

`authority_kind` answers urgency:

Kind	Meaning	Sources
`medical_society`	proposes changes that may lead to a policy change; not urgent	`pubmed` (practice guidelines, mostly society-authored)
`federal_recommendation`	recommends; does not bind payers directly	`uspstf`, `cdc_acip_adult`, `cdc_acip_child`
`federal_requirement`	binding rules, coverage determinations and approvals; active changes are tracked	`federal_register`, `ecfr`, `cms_coverage`, `openfda_drug_label`, `openfda_device_510k`
`payer_policy`	the payer's own documents	`cpb_upload`

Notes: USPSTF grade A and B recommendations become coverage requirements for most plans under the ACA, so urgency can also depend on the grade; `authority_kind` is the source-level default only. `pubmed` mixes many societies under one key until it is split by journal or society. Whether a federal rule is proposed or final is a property of the document, not the source, and is not modelled yet.

`source_document`

An immutable fetched or uploaded file. One row per distinct set of bytes per source.

Column	Type	Key / constraint	Notes
document_id	text	**PK**	`{source_key}-{sha256[:16]}`
source_key	text	**FK** → source, not null	a key from `GET /sources`, or `cpb_upload`
retrieved_at	timestamptz	not null	
storage_uri	text	not null	object key, see Object storage
content_sha256	char(64)	not null	
media_type	text	not null	e.g. `application/pdf`. Not on the diagram; needed to read the file
origin_url	text		where it was fetched from; null for uploads
		unique (source_key, content_sha256)	a re-fetch of identical bytes is skipped

`guideline`

Column	Type	Key / constraint	Notes
guideline_id	text	**PK**	random hex
source_key	text	**FK** → source, not null	
document_id	text	**FK** → source_document, **unique**, on delete cascade	one guideline per document
title	text	not null	
published	date	not null	falls back to the retrieval date if the document states none
version	text		
strength	text		a grade of `strength_system`, e.g. `B`
strength_system	text	check ∈ `StrengthSystem`	grades are never normalised across systems

`strength` and `strength_system` are both set or both null, and the grade must belong to the system. SQL enforces this with table checks, `Guideline` with a validator, and `tests/test_schema.py` fails if the SQL and `STRENGTH_VALUES` drift. The extraction prompt lists the allowed pairs; a mismatched pair fails that document, which the job records.

`strength_system`	`strength` values	Scale	Not stored
`uspstf`	`A`, `B`, `C`, `D`, `I`	USPSTF letter grades (definitions since July 2012); `I` = insufficient evidence	
`acc_aha`	`1`, `2a`, `2b`, `3_no_benefit`, `3_harm`	ACC/AHA class of recommendation	level of evidence (A, B-R, B-NR, C-LD, C-EO), an independent axis
`grade`	`strong`, `conditional`	GRADE strength of recommendation	certainty of evidence (high to very low), an independent axis

A document graded under any other scheme, or with no single overall grade, gets both columns null; add the scheme to the enum when one is needed. A guideline with many recommendations carries only its overall grade here.

`policy`

Column	Type	Key / constraint	Notes
policy_number	text	**PK**	e.g. `0584`
doc_type	text	not null, check ∈ `PolicyDocumentType`	
title	text	not null	
coverage_effect	text	not null, check ∈ `CoverageEffect`	the predominant determination
effective_date	date	not null	
last_reviewed	date		
document_id	text	**FK** → source_document, not null	not on the diagram; the file it was parsed from

`watched_triggers` is derived from `doc_type` in Python (`WATCHED_TRIGGERS` in `models.py`) and not stored. It is a routing hint and must never exclude a policy.

`guideline_criterion` and `policy_criterion`

Same columns, two tables, so each owner and each update history get a typed foreign key.

Column	Type	Key / constraint	Notes
criterion_id	text	**PK**	`{parent_id}:{position}`
parent_id	text	**FK** → guideline (or policy), on delete cascade	`guideline_id` / `policy_number`
position	int	not null	order within the owner, from 1; not on the diagram
text	text	not null	
concept_words	text[]	not null, default `{}`	
embedding	vector(1536)	HNSW index, cosine	OpenAI `text-embedding-3-small`; not on the diagram

`needs_update` is derived when criteria are read: true if a row in the matching `*_criterion_update` table has status `pending`.

`code`

Column	Type	Key / constraint
policy_number	text	**PK** part, **FK** → policy, on delete cascade
system	text	**PK** part, check ∈ `CodeSystem`
value	text	**PK** part

`guideline_criterion_update` and `policy_criterion_update` (no writer yet)

Column	Type	Key / constraint	Notes
update_id	text	**PK**	
criterion_id	text	**FK** → `guideline_criterion` / `policy_criterion`, on delete cascade	the history relation
kind	text	check ∈ `revise`, `retire`	
origin	text	check ∈ `guideline_change`, `manual`	
revised	jsonb		the proposed `GuidelineCriterion` / `PolicyCriterion` when kind is `revise`
document_id	text	**FK** → source_document	the guideline document behind it
editor	text		
rationale	text	not null	
recorded_at	timestamptz	not null	
status	text	check ∈ `pending`, `accepted`, `rejected`; default `pending`	

`criterion_match` (no writer yet)

Column	Type	Key / constraint	Notes
match_id	bigint identity	**PK**	surrogate: `policy_criterion_id` may be null
guideline_criterion_id	text	**FK** → guideline_criterion	
policy_number	text	**FK** → policy	not on the diagram; with a null counterpart it is the only record of which policy had none
policy_criterion_id	text	**FK** → policy_criterion, null = no counterpart	
similarity	real	check 0–1	
divergence	text		
		unique nulls not distinct (guideline_criterion_id, policy_number, policy_criterion_id)	needs Postgres 15

The diagram's `guideline_id` was dropped: it follows from the guideline criterion.

job

Column	Type	Notes
job_id	text **PK**	
kind	text	`ingest`, `atomize`, `parse_cpb`
status	text	`queued` → `running` → `succeeded` or `failed`
detail	jsonb	inputs, then result counts and per-document failures
error	text	set when the whole job fails
created_at, finished_at	timestamptz	

Known limits of this model

- Re-parsing a CPB with the same `policy_number` deletes and replaces the policy, its criteria and codes — and, by cascade, any `policy_criterion_update` history on those criteria. Policy versioning has to be decided together with matching.
- Re-atomizing a document replaces its guideline the same way.
- There is no version chain between two guidelines on the same topic; each fetch that changes the bytes is a new `SourceDocument` and a new `Guideline`.

Guideline sources

All connectors are in `policy_radar/sources.py`, one function each, verified against live responses on 2026-09-22. Each returns one file per document, as the source served it. Keys are per endpoint or page, and each has a row in the `source` table. Runs are capped at 1,000 records per endpoint (`MAX_RECORDS_PER_ENDPOINT`); a capped run logs a warning.

Key	Source	What one document is	Change detection	Auth
`openfda_drug_label`	openFDA `drug/label`	one label version, JSON	`effective_time` ≥ since	`OPENFDA_API_KEY` optional
`openfda_device_510k`	openFDA `device/510k`	one 510(k), JSON	`decision_date` ≥ since	`OPENFDA_API_KEY` optional
`federal_register`	Federal Register v1	one HHS/CMS/FDA rule or proposed rule, raw text	`publication_date` ≥ since	none
`ecfr`	eCFR versioner, titles 42 and 45	one amended CFR section, XML	substantive versions with `amendment_date` ≥ since	none
`cms_coverage`	CMS Coverage API	one NCD, JSON	`last_updated_sort` ≥ since	none
`uspstf`	Prevention TaskForce API	one specific recommendation plus its topic, JSON	none in the API; content hash	`USPSTF_API_KEY` required
`pubmed`	NCBI E-utilities	one “practice guideline” article, XML	`mdat` ≥ since	`NCBI_API_KEY` optional
`cdc_acip_adult`	CDC ACIP adult immunization schedule page	one page, HTML	content hash	none
`cdc_acip_child`	CDC ACIP child and adolescent schedule page	one page, HTML	content hash	none

Open points:

- **CMS LCDs are not ingested.** Their detail endpoint needs a token, and requesting the token accepts the AMA/ADA/AHA license terms. That is your call to make.
- **USPSTF key parameter** is undocumented; the code sends `key=`. It fails loudly if the API answers with its “no key” placeholder.
- **openFDA volume**: about 5,000 label versions a month, each an LLM call when atomized. The cap bounds this; filtering to relevant drugs needs a decision.
- Pages with no API get one function and one `source` row each (the two CDC ACIP schedules today). Add society pages the same way.

Pipelines

All three run as FastAPI background tasks in the API process and report through the `job` table. A job still running when the process stops stays `running`; that is acceptable for v0. A failure on one document is recorded in the job’s `detail.failed` and the run continues.

Ingest (`POST /guidelines/ingest/{source_key}?since=YYYY-MM-DD`): call the source’s connector for everything published since `since` (default: the source’s last new document, or 30 days back on first run) → for each file, write it to object storage and insert a `source_document` row unless the same bytes are already stored. Result: `{since, fetched, new}`.

Atomize (`POST /guidelines/atomize`): for every guideline-source document with no `guideline` row → send the document to OpenAI (PDF as a file, HTML reduced to text, JSON/XML as text) with a fixed instruction and the

`ExtractedGuideline` schema → assign `guideline_id` and criterion ids → embed each criterion's text → write `guideline` and `criterion` rows in one transaction. Result: `{processed, failed}`.

Parse CPBs (`POST /policies/documents` then `POST /policies/parse`): uploads (PDF, HTML or plain text) are stored as `source_document` rows with `source_key = cpb_upload`. Parsing does the same as atomize with the `ExtractedPolicy` schema and writes `policy`, `criterion` and `code` rows. Result: `{processed, failed}`.

Prompts and extraction schemas are in `policy_radar/llm.py`.

API

Method	Path	Does
GET	`/health`	liveness
GET	`/sources`	ingestible sources: key, name, authority, authority kind, trigger type, endpoint
POST	`/guidelines/ingest/{source_key}`	start an ingest job → `{job_id}`
POST	`/guidelines/atomize`	start an atomize job → `{job_id}`
GET	`/guidelines`	list guidelines
GET	`/guidelines/{guideline_id}`	one guideline with criteria
POST	`/policies/documents`	upload CPB files (multipart `files`) → `{stored, duplicates}`
POST	`/policies/parse`	start a CPB parse job → `{job_id}`
GET	`/policies`	list policies
GET	`/policies/{policy_number}`	one policy with criteria, codes, watched triggers
GET	`/jobs/{job_id}`	job status and result

No authentication yet.

Configuration

Every setting comes from `.env`; `example.env` lists them. `DATABASE_URL` and `OPENAI_API_KEY` are required and the app does not start without them.

Code layout

```
db/schema.sql              tables, keys, indexes
scripts/create_schema.py   applies schema.sql to DATABASE_URL
policy_radar/
  enums.py                 controlled vocabularies (mirrored by schema checks)
  models.py                domain models (one per table)
  config.py                settings from .env
  storage.py               object storage
  db.py                    all SQL
  sources.py               one fetch function per guideline source
  llm.py                   OpenAI extraction and embeddings
  pipelines.py             ingest, atomize, parse
```

```
  api.py                    FastAPI routes
tests/
```

Rendering

```
cd docs && pandoc BACKEND_SPEC.md -o BACKEND_SPEC.pdf --pdf-engine=weasyprint --css pdf.css
```